AppealDesk

Your Homeowner Savings Guide

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Property Tax Exemptions & Credits You May Qualify For

Based on your property in Sonoma County, California, we have identified the following property tax exemption and credit programs that may apply to you. Each program listed below includes eligibility requirements, estimated savings, and instructions for how to apply. *Since we do not collect personal information such as age or veteran status, each program below is listed as "If you qualify..." so you can identify which programs may apply to your household.*

Homeowners' Exemption

Reduces the assessed value of your home by $7,000, resulting in a modest tax savings.

Estimated Savings: $70-$80/year

Eligibility: Must own and occupy the property as your principal residence as of January 1.
Deadline: February 15 (late filing may be accepted for full year; after the deadline partial year credit)
Form: BOE-266
Apply: https://www.boe.ca.gov/proptaxes/faqs/exemptions.htm
A one-time filing. The savings are modest because California's exemption amount is small. The much larger benefit for California homeowners comes from Proposition 13's 2% annual cap on assessed value increases.

Proposition 19 (Transfer of Base Year Value)

Homeowners 55 or older can transfer their current property tax base to a new home anywhere in California, up to 3 times. If the new home is more expensive, you only pay the difference in value.

Estimated Savings: Can save thousands per year by preserving a low Prop 13 base

Eligibility: Must be 55 or older (or severely disabled, or a disaster victim). The original property must have been your principal residence.
Deadline: Must file a claim within 2 years of the transfer
Form: BOE-19-P
Apply: https://www.boe.ca.gov/prop19/
Replaced Propositions 60 and 90. This is one of the most valuable tax benefits for long-term California homeowners looking to downsize or relocate within the state.

Disabled Veterans' Exemption

Exemption of $161,083-$241,627 of assessed value for qualifying disabled veterans (amounts adjusted annually for inflation).

Estimated Savings: $1,600-$2,800/year

Eligibility: Must be a veteran with a 100% service-connected disability, or be totally disabled and have a household income below the qualifying threshold.
Deadline: Must file a claim with your county assessor
Form: BOE-261-G
Apply: https://www.boe.ca.gov/proptaxes/faqs/exemptions.htm
The basic exemption ($161,083) has no income limit for 100% disabled veterans. The low-income exemption ($241,627) requires household income below $76,761. Amounts are adjusted annually.

Disabled Persons Exemption (Base Year Value Transfer)
Severely disabled persons can transfer their current property tax base year value to a replacement home, similar to the Prop 19 benefit for seniors.

Estimated Savings: Varies based on existing Prop 13 base

Eligibility: Must be severely and permanently disabled as defined by Revenue and Taxation Code. Must be for a principal residence.
Deadline: Within 2 years of the transfer
Form: BOE-19-D
Apply: https://www.boe.ca.gov/prop19/
This allows disabled persons to move to a more accessible home without losing their low Prop 13 assessed value.

Surviving Spouse
California does not have a separate widow/widower exemption. Surviving spouses of disabled veterans may qualify for the disabled veterans' exemption.

Proposition 13 (2% Annual Assessment Cap)
Limits increases in assessed value to no more than 2% per year, regardless of market value changes. Reassessment to market value only occurs on a change of ownership or new construction.

Estimated Savings: Often saves thousands per year, especially for long-term owners

Eligibility: Automatic for all property owners in California.
Deadline: Automatic
This is the cornerstone of California property tax law (since 1978). As long as you do not trigger a "change in ownership" event, your assessed value grows at only 2% per

year. Understanding what constitutes a change in ownership is critical to protecting your Prop 13 base.

Parent-Child Exclusion (Prop 19, Limited)
Transfer of a primary residence between parents and children may be excluded from reassessment if the child uses it as their primary residence. The excluded amount is limited to the existing base year value plus $1 million.

Estimated Savings: Preserves Prop 13 base, potentially saving thousands

Eligibility: Parent-to-child or child-to-parent transfer of a primary residence. The recipient must file within 1 year and use it as their primary residence.

Property Tax Postponement (State Program)
Allows eligible homeowners to postpone payment of property taxes on their primary residence. The state pays the taxes and places a lien on the property.

Estimated Savings: Defers entire tax bill (5% annual interest)

Eligibility: Must be 62 or older, blind, or disabled with household income of $49,017 or less and at least 40% equity in the home.

Source: https://www.boe.ca.gov/proptaxes/faqs/exemptions.htm

These programs are independent of your property assessment. You can apply for exemptions regardless of whether you file a property tax appeal. Even if your assessment is accurate, you may be overpaying taxes simply because you have not applied for exemptions you qualify for.

Exemption programs and eligibility requirements change periodically. The information above is current as of 2026-03. Verify current requirements with your county assessor's office before applying.

Reassessment Protection Guide

Understanding what triggers a reassessment of your property can help you protect your current assessed value and avoid unexpected tax increases.

California Proposition 13 Protection

Under Prop 13, your assessed value can only increase by a maximum of 2% per year, regardless of how much your home's market value rises. This protection is one of the most valuable benefits available to California homeowners.

- **"Change in ownership"** triggers a full reassessment to current market value. This includes most sales, adding or removing someone from the title, and certain trust transfers.
- **Transfers between spouses** are excluded from reassessment (not considered a change in ownership).
- **Parent-child transfers** of a primary residence may qualify for exclusion under Prop 19, but the child must use it as their primary residence and the exclusion is capped.
- **New construction** (including major remodels) triggers reassessment only on the value of the new construction, not the entire property.

Actions That May Trigger Reassessment

- **Building permits:** Pulling a permit for renovations, additions, or structural changes will typically notify the assessor of improvements to your property.
- **Major visible renovations:** Exterior improvements such as new roofing, siding, additions, or added structures (pools, garages, ADUs) may prompt a reassessment even without a permit.
- **Listing on MLS:** Listing your home for sale, even temporarily, can expose a higher market value to the assessor, especially if the listing price significantly exceeds your current assessed value.
- **Refinance appraisals:** In some jurisdictions, a high appraisal obtained during refinancing can become part of the public record and influence your assessment.
- **Insurance rebuild valuations:** Replacement cost estimates from insurance claims can signal a higher property value.
- **Adding structures:** Pools, accessory dwelling units (ADUs), detached garages, and other permanent structures increase your property's value.

How to Protect Your Current Assessment

- **Document your home's current condition:** Take dated photos showing any deferred maintenance, needed repairs, or functional issues. This documentation can support a lower valuation if challenged.
- **Keep records of needed repairs:** Maintain a list of deferred maintenance items (aging HVAC, roof wear, plumbing issues). These reduce your home's value relative to comparable properties.

- **Understand your reassessment schedule:** Know when your county's next reassessment year is so you are not caught off guard by changes.
- **Review your annual assessment notice:** When you receive your notice of assessed value, compare it to the prior year and to recent comparable sales in your neighborhood.

Your state's reassessment cycle: California reassesses property on a annual basis. Understanding this cycle helps you anticipate when your assessment might change.

What to Do If Your Assessment Increases

If your assessed value increases significantly, you have the right to appeal. The key steps are:

- Review your appeal deadline (see the Appeal Window section of this packet)
- Gather comparable sales data showing your home's actual market value
- Document any property-specific factors that reduce value (condition issues, location drawbacks, functional obsolescence)
- File your appeal before the deadline

AppealDesk can generate a comprehensive evidence packet if your assessment rises in the future. Visit https://www.appealdesk.com to get started.

Understanding Your Property Tax Bill

Your property tax bill includes more than just the base property tax. Understanding each component helps you identify which charges can be challenged and where potential savings exist.

Your Tax Breakdown at a Glance
Based on your current assessment of **$910,207** and annual tax of **$10,703.7**, your effective tax rate is approximately **1.18%**.
The effective rate includes all taxing jurisdictions (school district, county, city, and special districts) combined.

How Your Tax Is Calculated

The core formula is: **Assessed Value x Tax Rate = Base Property Tax**. Your total bill then adds special district assessments, voter-approved bonds, and various fees on top of this base amount.

Common Line Items You May See

- **School district levy:** Typically the largest portion (often 40-50% of total). Funds local public schools and sometimes community colleges.
- **County general fund:** Covers county services including roads, courts, public safety, and administration.
- **City/municipal tax:** Funds city services such as police, fire, parks, and infrastructure. Only applies if you live within city limits.
- **Fire/emergency services district:** Funds local fire protection and emergency medical services. Common in unincorporated areas.
- **Library district:** Funds local library operations and programs.
- **Stormwater/drainage fees:** Based on impervious surface area. Some jurisdictions bill these separately from the tax bill.
- **Voter-approved bonds:** Debt service on bonds approved by voters for schools, infrastructure, parks, or other public projects.
- **Solid waste assessment:** Some jurisdictions include trash collection fees on the property tax bill.
- **Special improvement districts:** Charges for lighting, sidewalks, or other neighborhood-level improvements.

Which Charges Can Be Challenged?

Challengeable **Ad valorem (value-based) taxes:** The core property tax based on your assessed value. This is what a property tax appeal addresses. Reducing your assessed value reduces this portion of your bill proportionally.

Separate Process **Special assessments and fees:** Flat-rate charges for specific services (stormwater, solid waste, special districts) often have their own dispute process. Contact your county for details.

Not Challengeable **Voter-approved bonds:** Bond levies approved at the ballot box generally cannot be individually challenged through the appeal process.

Where Your Tax Dollars Typically Go

While the exact breakdown varies by jurisdiction, a typical distribution of property tax revenue is:

~45%	~25%	~15%	~15%
Schools	County Services	City/Municipal	Special Districts

These are national averages. Your jurisdiction's breakdown may differ. Check your tax bill or county website for the exact distribution.

Energy Savings & Rebate Finder

Beyond property tax savings, significant financial incentives are available for home energy improvements. Many homeowners are unaware of these programs, which can save hundreds to thousands of dollars per year on energy costs.

Federal Programs (Available Nationwide)

Energy Efficient Home Improvement Credit (25C)
Tax credit of up to $3,200/year for qualifying home energy improvements including insulation, exterior doors, windows, central air conditioners, heat pumps, water heaters, and electrical panel upgrades.

Up to $3,200/year ($1,200 general limit + $2,000 for heat pumps/heat pump water heaters)

Eligibility: Available to all homeowners for improvements to their primary residence. Must meet ENERGY STAR or other efficiency standards.
How to claim: Claim on your federal tax return using IRS Form 5695. Keep receipts and manufacturer certification statements.
Available through: Through December 31, 2032
Details: https://www.energystar.gov/about/federal_tax_credits/tax_credits_702

Residential Clean Energy Credit (25D)
30% tax credit on the cost of solar panels, solar water heaters, battery storage, geothermal heat pumps, fuel cells, and small wind turbines.

30% of total system cost (no maximum limit)

Eligibility: Available to homeowners for installations on any home they own (primary or secondary). Must be a new installation, not previously used.
How to claim: Claim on your federal tax return using IRS Form 5695. Unused credit can carry forward to future tax years.
Available through: 30% through 2032, then 26% in 2033, 22% in 2034
Details:
https://www.energystar.gov/about/federal_tax_credits/renewable_energy_tax_credits

High-Efficiency Electric Home Rebate Act (HEEHRA)
Point-of-sale rebates for electrification upgrades: up to $8,000 for heat pumps, $1,750 for heat pump water heaters, $840 for electric stoves/dryers, $4,000 for electrical panel upgrades, and $1,600 for insulation.

Up to $14,000 total in rebates per household

Eligibility: Income-qualified: households earning less than 150% of area median income get the largest rebates. Moderate-income households (150-200% AMI) get

50% rebates. Above 200% AMI are not eligible for HEEHRA rebates.
How to claim: Applied as a point-of-sale discount through participating contractors. Check with your state energy office for availability.
Available through: Funds available until September 30, 2031 or until exhausted
Details: https://www.energy.gov/scep/home-energy-rebates-programs

California Programs

Self-Generation Incentive Program (SGIP)
Rebates for battery storage systems and other distributed energy resources. Provides significant incentives for home battery installations.
Details: https://www.selfgenerationsolar.com/
Battery storage rebates can cover 25-85% of system costs depending on income level and location. Higher incentives available in fire-threat areas.

California Solar Property Tax Exclusion
Active solar energy systems are excluded from property tax reassessment through 2027. Your property taxes will not increase from adding solar.
This is automatic under California law (Revenue and Taxation Code Section 73). No application needed for systems installed through January 1, 2027.

Utility Rate Optimization (NEM 3.0)
Net Energy Metering allows solar homeowners to receive credits for excess energy exported to the grid.
NEM 3.0 (effective April 2023) changed the export credit rates. Pairing solar with battery storage maximizes savings under the new structure.

Contact your utility (PG&E, SCE, SDG&E) for current programs. California utilities offer some of the most extensive energy efficiency rebate programs in the country.

Where to Start

For maximum savings, energy efficiency experts recommend this order of improvements:

1. **Air sealing and insulation first.** This has the highest return on investment and enables right-sizing of HVAC equipment. Typical savings: 15-30% on heating and cooling costs.
2. **HVAC heat pump upgrade.** Heat pumps provide both heating and cooling, qualify for the largest rebates, and can reduce energy costs by 30-50% compared to traditional systems.
3. **Water heater replacement.** Heat pump water heaters use 60-70% less energy than conventional models and qualify for substantial rebates.

Federal tax credits require filing IRS Form 5695 with your annual tax return. State and utility programs may have different application processes. Program availability and amounts are subject to change. Consult with a tax professional regarding your specific eligibility.

Property Tax Watch: Never Overpay Again

You have taken the first step by understanding your current assessment. Property Tax Watch ensures you stay ahead of any future changes, with automatic monitoring and alerts when your assessment increases.

- ✓ **Annual assessment change alerts** delivered to your inbox when your county updates your property value
- ✓ **Automatic overassessment detection** comparing your assessed value against current market data
- ✓ **Filing deadline reminders** so you never miss your window to appeal

Activate Your Free 12-Month Monitoring

https://www.appealdesk.com/tax-watch

Appeal Window & Deadline Summary

In California, the process for challenging your property assessment is called an "appeal." Here is what you need to know about timing and deadlines for Sonoma County.

Mark Your Calendar
California Appeal Deadline: September 15 or November 30
Review Board: Assessment Appeals Board
County: Sonoma County, California

The typical appeal window in California is **July – November**. During this period, homeowners can file a formal appeal of their assessed property value.

When Your Appeal Window Opens
Your appeal window typically opens when you receive your **Notice of Assessment** from the county. This notice is mailed to property owners, usually in the spring. **Keep this notice.** You will need it to file your appeal. It contains your property identification number, current assessed value, and instructions for filing.

California Appeal Process

If you choose to appeal, the process follows these levels:

1. Assessor (Informal)
2. Assessment Appeals Board
3. Superior Court

An **informal review** is available before the formal hearing in most jurisdictions. This is often the fastest path to resolution.

If you need a complete evidence packet to support your appeal, AppealDesk can generate one with comparable sales analysis, a cover letter, and filing instructions tailored to your property. Visit https://www.appealdesk.com to get started.

This guide is for informational purposes. Exemption eligibility and program details should be verified with your county assessor's office before applying. Energy rebate programs are subject to change and funding availability. Consult with a tax professional regarding your specific eligibility for tax credits.